

Which Has the Brightest Future: French, Spanish, Russian, or Arabic?

Zhihu

In order of prospects:

Spanish + Portuguese (first choice) > French > Spanish > Arabic > Portuguese > Russian

I have studied Russian (on italki), am currently learning Spanish, my child is learning French, and later I plan to learn some Arabic as well. So I know something about this question. These languages will be the main international languages of communication after English and Chinese in the future, and are worth analysing in depth.

Russian is basically used only in Russia, Belarus, and the Central Asian countries, with a total population of a little over 200 million. The Central Asian countries are also beginning to de-Russify, so Russian is overall in decline — last among the international languages.

Let me focus on Spanish/Portuguese, French, and Arabic.

Besides Spain, Spanish is the common language of Latin America: apart from Brazil, which speaks Portuguese, almost all countries speak Spanish. Spanish speakers in Latin America currently number over 400 million, rising to 500 million by 2050. Most of Latin America's population peaks before 2050, after which it stops growing and slowly declines after 2050. Adding Spain's roughly 50 million, the peak population of the Spanish-speaking countries is about 550 million. Other countries also have sizeable Spanish-speaking populations (the United States, for instance), but since the national lingua franca there is English, they are of limited relevance to us language learners.

However, Spanish and Portuguese are very close kin. Portuguese speakers can basically understand Spanish. Knowing Portuguese makes learning Spanish easy, and vice versa.

The Portuguese-speaking (lusophone) countries are mainly four: Brazil, Angola, Mozambique, and Portugal.

Brazil has a population of 200 million; Portugal, 10 million. Neither will grow much in the future.

Angola's population will rise to 70 million by 2050 and 130–150 million by 2100.

Mozambique's population will reach over 60 million by 2050 and 100 million by 2100.

Portugal's long colonial history in Africa drove Portuguese deep into local societies. In Angola, 70% of the population uses Portuguese at home; among the urban population, over 85%. In Mozambique,

more than 15% of the population currently speaks Portuguese as a first language, with 38% in cities. In these two countries, the position of Portuguese can basically no longer be replaced by any other language.

By 2050, the population of the Portuguese-speaking countries will reach about 350 million; by 2100, at least 400 million or more.

Hence, by 2050, the Portuguese + Spanish population will reach about 900 million, and may be maintained at around 900 million before 2100.

Everyone knows there are many French-speaking countries in West and North Africa, but many of them are undergoing a process of de-Francisation. The main reasons: strong indigenous languages within the country, a scarcity of native French speakers, and the fact that French's international standing is far below English — all of which reduces the younger generation's willingness to learn it.

The details are as follows:

Morocco, Tunisia, and Algeria in North Africa: virtually everyone speaks the indigenous language, Arabic.

Chad: Arabic is spoken by 50% of the population.

Niger: Hausa is spoken by 55% of the population.

Burkina Faso: Mooré is spoken by 50% of the population.

Mali: Bambara is spoken by 50% of the population.

Madagascar: nearly everyone speaks Malagasy.

Senegal: Wolof is spoken by 80% of the population.

In the countries above, French's position is trending downward in the long run, but since several generations have mainly studied French, it will retain a special status for a long time. Still, the number of young people who know French may be decreasing, while those turning to English increase. This is very evident in North Africa. In West Africa, as the decolonisation movement develops, the share of the principal indigenous languages will rise further, replacing French as the domestic lingua franca.

The countries where French can maintain its status as a common language in the future are:

Benin: 33% of the population speaks French; the largest indigenous language, Fon, is spoken by 24%, with 17% native speakers.

Côte d'Ivoire: 36% speak French; there are many indigenous languages, but none with a large share challenges French.

Cameroon: 83% of the population is francophone, and 90% of those use French at home.

Togo: 14% are native French speakers; 80% speak French; no major indigenous language challenges French.

DR Congo: 12% are native French speakers; 50% speak French and 74% understand it; the biggest challenger is Lingala, spoken by 59%. French's position remains solid for now.

Congo-Brazzaville: 61% speak French.

Gabon: 14% are native French speakers; 80% speak French. Fang is the largest indigenous language, at 32%.

In these countries, the position of French is maintained because there are native French speakers (many of them middle class and ruling class), or because French penetration is already very high. With Africa's urbanisation, French's position will rise further.

Although these countries are not many, their population growth is marked. Their expected populations in 2050 and 2100:

Benin: 24 million in 2050; 40 million in 2100. Côte d'Ivoire: 55 million in 2050; 100 million in 2100. Cameroon: 50 million in 2050; 88 million in 2100. Togo: 15 million in 2050; 25 million in 2100. DR Congo: 217 million in 2050; 430 million in 2100. Congo-Brazzaville: 10 million in 2050; 20 million in 2100. Gabon: 4 million in 2050; 7 million in 2100.

Thus the francophone countries of Africa will reach 325 million in 2050 and about 700 million in 2100. Fertility may fall more than expected between 2050 and 2100, but the francophone African population will be at least 600 million; adding France and Belgium in Europe, the world's francophone population will reach at least 700 million — higher than the Spanish-speaking population, but lower than the Spanish + Portuguese population.

The Arabic-speaking population is currently about 400 million, growing to 700 million by 2050 and 900 million to 1 billion by 2100. In terms of population, Arabic seems more valuable than French, close to Spanish + Portuguese. But Arabic's prospects are inferior to Spanish and French, for two reasons:

- 1) English penetration in the Arab countries will keep rising. In the Middle East, English is the common language of business. The Arab countries also make heavy use of English in higher education — the Gulf states, Egypt, and even Algeria, which formerly used French, are switching to English. The richest Arab countries, the Gulf states, have brought in so many migrant workers that English has become the common language of communication across ethnic groups within the country. This is unlike the Spanish, Portuguese, and French countries, where English penetration is clearly low relative to their urbanisation levels.

2) Standard Arabic differs too greatly from the dialects; learning only standard Arabic makes it hard to communicate with people of various countries.

So my view is: learn both Spanish and Portuguese — the lowest cost, the greatest benefit. Second, learn French. Finally, if you don't fear difficulty, learn Arabic (it is said that with the effort to master Arabic, you could have learned Spanish, Portuguese, and French all together). Russian is of the least value; if you like Russia, you can learn it.

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